7.2.2 Complications:

Poor immunity:

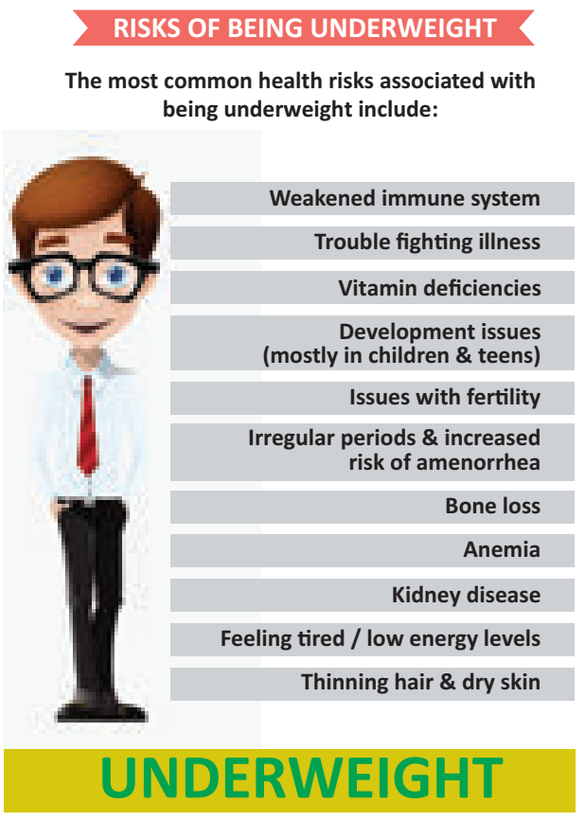
Low body weight puts a person at increased risk for infections and disease.Due to less consumption of protein, fat and other nutrients, such as antioxidants which help support a strong, functioning immune system.

Gynaecological problems:

Amenorrhoea, infertility and pregnancy related complications and low birth weight babies are common in underweight mothers .

Osteoporosis:

Drastic weight loss impairs the nutrient absorption capabilities of the individual. When calcium is not consumed and absorbed in proper amounts may lead to weak and fragile bones causing osteoporosis.



7.2.3 Dietary Principles:

Any underlying cause of underweight must be dealt with as a first priority. Nutrition support and dietary changes are effective along with or after treatment of the underlying disorder. Then a balanced diet should be planned based on the requirement.

A high calorie, high protein, high fat, diet liberal vitamin intake is recommended.

Energy:

The total calorie intake should be 500 to 1000 Kcal in excess of the daily needs in order to result a gain in weight by half to one kilogram in a week. The person may be given 30 – 35 Kcal per Kg body weight per day. The calorie should be increased gradually over a period of one or two weeks to avoid digestive disturbances.

Carbohydrates:

Gradual amounts of easy to digest carbohydrates should be included in the diet. The intake of dietary fibre should be minimized so as to prepare meals which are nutrient dense and have a small volume. Include more of high calorie vegetables like potatoes, colocasia and yam instead of raddish, cucumber, leafy vegetables which are low in carbohydrate content.

Proteins:

Underweight individuals generally have lean body mass and may benefit by consuming around 1.2 g per kg body weight of protein per day. A combination of both animal and plant proteins should be incorporated.

Fats:

Fats are capable of increasing energy value of diet without adding much bulk to it. Add extra fat gradually, a sudden increase in fatty foods like butter, cream and oil may produce diarrhoea. About 30 % of calories should come from unsaturated sources of fat.

Vitamins and minerals:

If the diet provides good amount of fresh fruits and vegetables, vitamin or mineral supplements are usually not required.

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